



AP PHOTO/AL SENG SENG

OR IDENTITY

government demand a fair share of the nation's wealth

going by the size of the Tamil protest last month, many say progress has bypassed the community. "Otherwise why would 20,000 Tamils gather in the city and protest in anger," said S. K. Dewamany, a Government backbencher in the Malaysian parliament.

The demonstrators wanted to march on to the British mission, located in the Ampang diplomatic enclave in Kuala Lumpur, to submit a memorandum urging the Queen of England to help them in a legal case brought against the British government. In the class action suit, filed in London in August, Hindraf chairman P. Waythamoorthy has demanded that the British

pay \$4 trillion (Rs 157 lakh crore) in damages to atone for "150 years of exploitation" of ethnic Indians by their former colonial masters. But the real intention was to humiliate the Malaysian government. The protest brought the city to standstill for six hours and made headlines globally that embarrassed the Government.

"We have nothing to celebrate in our lives. They (Malays) are going places. They are vice-chancellors, professors, astronauts but we are going nowhere," says Muniandy Ramakrishnan, 28, an odd job worker who travelled in a bus with 70 other Tamils from Alor Star, a northern city bordering Thailand, to

register his anger last month. "Even to be a government clerk is an impossible dream for us," he says echoing the views of most working-class Tamils. The protest by Tamils—who form 80 per cent of the two million people of Indian origin in a population of 27 million—is seen as a rude awakening in the land of the plenty. "The problem is that the plenty is in the hands of a few. There are Indians and Chinese who are poor and bypassed by development," says Opposition leader Lim Kit Siang. According to the 2004 United Nations Human Development report, Malaysia has the highest income disparity in South-East Asia. The report says the richest 10 per cent of the Malaysian population have a 38.4 per cent share of income compared to the poorest 10 per cent who have a share of 1.7 per cent.

The Indian problem is a historical and inherited one. In the colonial scheme, Tamils were at the bottom of the hierarchy as unskilled labourers in plantations. As the colonial economy boomed, the non-Tamils prospered and moved into high-skill professions, business or migrated. They saw more prosperity during the boom years of the 1990s, but Tamils suffered as they were uprooted when cities expanded and ate up plantations, and they ended up as urban squatters. Some did experience mobility through education, but according to Ramasamy Palanisamy, former professor of political science at the National University of Malaysia, "the bottom 60 per cent of Tamils could not escape because of illiteracy, poverty and the lack of skills. The Government didn't pay attention to them and, despite numerous warnings from researchers, they were ignored because they were voiceless."

"The NEP's (New Economic Policy) aim was to eradicate poverty, but in its implementation it only lifted poor Malays into the middle class, neglecting Indians," says Palanisamy, referring to Bhumiputra (sons of the soil), the affirmative action policy introduced in 1970 that raised incomes among native Malays, who form 60 per cent of the population. Says opposition legislator Kulasegaran Murugesan, "Our share of the national wealth did not grow but stagnated. It was 1.5 per cent in 1970, but is 1 per cent now. The Malay share jumped from 3 per cent to 40 per